

If an AI coding agent can think harder, should we always ask it to?

Choosing reasoning effort in Claude Code and Codex.

Audience vote →
Light, Medium, or Deep?
What would you choose for your next coding task?

LIGHT
Fast · clear · reversible

MEDIUM
Context · coordination · tests

DEEP
Ambiguous · complex · high-risk

What does “reasoning effort” mean?

How much thinking
does the task
deserve?

More thinking is not
automatically better.

01

Context

How much code must it
understand?

02

Alternatives

How many approaches are
plausible?

03

Edge cases

What could fail?

04

Verification

How carefully must we
test?

Reasoning effort is a task decision—not a quality button.

Three levels. One question.

Choose the lowest reasoning level that can reliably solve the task.

01 · SPEED

Light

**Clear, local,
reversible.**

Simple helpers, boilerplate,
documentation, and routine
fixes.

02 · CONTEXT

Medium

Everyday development.

Normal features, related files,
project conventions, and tests.

03 · RISK

Deep

**Ambiguous, complex,
high-risk.**

Difficult bugs, architecture,
refactors, security, and
migration.

Same framework: Claude Code and Codex. Product labels may differ by interface.

Claude Code and Codex: same reasoning question

Choose the effort from the task—not from the tool's brand.

Light

Claude Code: Light
Codex: Light

Simple helpers · boilerplate · docs · routine fixes

Medium

Claude Code: Medium
Codex: Medium

Normal features · related files · tests · integration

Deep

Claude Code: Deep
Codex: Deep

Difficult bugs · refactors · architecture · security

Takeaway: the same task generally deserves the same reasoning level in both tools.

Easy task: how much thinking?

SCENARIO

“Add a helper that formats a date as
YYYY-MM-DD and write a unit test.”

What would you choose?

Claude Code? Codex?

Light, Medium, or Deep?

Light

Medium

Deep

Reveal:
Light / Light

The task is deterministic, local, reversible, and easy to verify. Deep reasoning adds time without much benefit.

Normal feature: how much thinking?

THE REQUEST

“Add CSV upload to an existing application. Validate rows, show errors, store valid records, and add tests.”

This touches validation, persistence, UI, and verification.

Your vote?

Choose a level for Claude Code and Codex.

☐ Light

☐ Medium

☐ Deep

REVEAL · CLAUDE CODE / CODEX

Medium / Medium

Why: the agent must inspect the repository, coordinate several files, and run tests—but the requirements are clear.

Enough thinking to integrate reliably.

Now the cost of being wrong is high.

THE SCENARIO

“Users are randomly logged out after refreshing the page.”

It happens in production, but not locally. Find the root cause and add a regression test.

Possible surfaces: cookies · tokens · session state · timing · deployment

AUDIENCE VOTE

Light?
Medium?
Deep?

LIGHT

MEDIUM

DEEP

REVEAL · CLAUDE CODE / CODEX

DEEP / DEEP

The symptom is ambiguous and cross-cutting. Deep reasoning gives the agent room to form hypotheses, inspect evidence, reproduce the failure, and verify the fix.

Deep reasoning is justified when investigation is more valuable than speed.

Deep reasoning cannot fix an unclear prompt.

AUDIENCE SCENARIO

“Fix the login bug.”

Ask the room: Which reasoning level would you choose?

First, ask for the missing pieces.

REPRODUCE

What steps trigger it?

EXPECTED

What should happen instead?

ENVIRONMENT

Where does it happen?

EVIDENCE

What logs or errors exist?

Correct first move: clarify the task before escalating reasoning.

A decision tree you can use tomorrow.

Same logic for Claude Code and Codex. Start with the task, then choose the effort.

01 · CLARITY

Clear and local?

One file.
Predictable.
Easy to verify.

02 · SCOPE

Normal feature?

Known requirements.
Several files.
Tests.

03 · RISK

Ambiguous or high-risk?

Hidden causes.
Production impact.
High cost of error.

04 · ESCALATE

Start lower.

Raise the level if the first attempt fails.

Light

Speed first.

Claude Code: Light

Codex: Light

Medium

Everyday coordination.

Claude Code: Medium

Codex: Medium

Deep

Investigate and verify.

Claude Code: Deep

Codex: Deep

Rule of thumb: use the lowest level that can reliably solve the task. Clarify before escalating.

Think just enough.

“Use Light for speed, Medium for everyday development, and Deep when the cost of being wrong is higher than the cost of waiting.”

LIGHT

Clear · local · reversible

MEDIUM

Context · coordination · tests

DEEP

Ambiguous · complex · high-risk

DISCUSSION PROMPT

What is a task where you changed reasoning level after the first attempt failed?

Same task → Claude Code level vs. Codex level → compare the result.

LET'S LEARN TOGETHER

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